



PHUKET THAILAND

Green Curry in Phuket

Centuries before Phuket began attracting sand-and-sea hedonists, it was an important trade center for Arab, Indian, Malay, Chinese, and Portuguese traders. Indian and Arab merchants brought green curry to Ayutthaya, the ancient Thai capital north of Bangkok, in the 14th to 16th centuries, but southern Thailand – especially the island of Phuket – claims its cooks are the masters.



Dubbed “Pearl of the South” by the tourist industry, Phuket (pronounced “Poo-get”) is Thailand’s largest, wealthiest, most populous, and most visited island, and a province in itself. The jagged coastal terrain of this 310-sq-mile (810-sq-km) island encompasses broad sandy bays, rocky peninsulas, limestone cliffs, and tropical vegetation. Phuket’s interior supports rice paddies and rubber, cashew-nut, cacao, pineapple, and coconut plantations, along with one last remnant of rainforest.

Formerly called Ko Thalang, and before that Junk Ceylon (an English corruption of the Malay “Tanjung Salang” or Cape Salang), Phuket has a culture all of its own. It combines Chinese and Portuguese influences with that of southern Thais and the *chao naam* (sea gypsies), an indigenous ocean-going people. About 35 percent of the island’s population are Thai Muslims, and there are about as many mosques as Buddhist temples. There’s lots for visitors to do (and spend money on), from sampling the delicious seafood to taking scuba-diving or snorkeling trips. And while most entertainment-seeking tourists flock to the flashy

beach towns of Patong, Karon, and Kata, there are calmer spots, notably Nai Han and Kamala, and even relatively untouched coastal areas in the north, such as Nai Yang, Nai Thon, and Mai Khao.

Phuket cuisine combines Chinese, Malay, and Thai elements to create brightly colored, heavily spiced dishes. One favorite is *kaeng khiaw-waan* – literally “sweet green curry” – which is served with *roti* (a round wheat flatbread descended from Indian paratha), *khanom jeen* (thin rice noodles, served cold), or rice. The curry’s green color derives from the plentiful presence of green chili peppers, cilantro root, kaffir lime peel, and green peppercorns, which are pounded with roasted coriander seed, fresh lemongrass, fresh galangal, fresh garlic, and salty shrimp paste to create the distinctive thick, green, pungent curry paste. This is cooked with coconut milk and eggplant, to make the curry slightly sweet and creamy, together with red chili peppers and the main ingredient – which might be chicken, beef, or seafood. Before serving, the dish is garnished with whole fresh sweet basil and chopped cilantro leaves, giving it a final fresh, tangy fragrance that’s hard to resist.



Above The crews of traditional longtail boats such as these at Kata Beach – one of the most popular in Phuket – offer swimming and snorkeling trips

What Else to Eat

Favorite Phuket dishes tend to draw from two primary sources, Chinese and Malay. **Ba-mee moo op hong teh** (egg noodles with roast pork in a soy-mushroom sauce) is a Chinese-sourced dish, as is **khao man kai**, literally “chicken oily rice,” but more commonly known as “Hainanese chicken rice.” From the Malay side comes **roti kaeng**, a simple meal of griddle-cooked round flatbread with curry (*kaeng*). One of the best-known southern Thai curries is **matsaman**, a fragrant Indian curry with peanuts and potatoes as well as chicken or beef. **Kaeng kayi** is a more local curry made with boiled cashew nuts. One dish that combines both Chinese and Thai elements, **khanom jeen**, is a delicious mix of thin rice noodles with a thick curry of fish, Chinese ginger, chili peppers, and coconut milk.

A Day in Phuket Town

Food is key to enjoying a great day out in Phuket town, so start the day with an eye-opening cup of *kopi* (strong Chinese-style black coffee) at Kopi de Phuket in the historic On On Hotel, accompanied by a plate of *roti kaeng kai* (flatbread with chicken curry) or some local candy from the large jars on the counter.

MORNING Meander through the historic **central district**, taking in the colorful Straits Settlement architecture, a 19th-century tradition. Walk up **Khao Rang**, sometimes called Phuket Hill, northwest of town, for views of the city, jungle, and sea. Take an outdoor table at Tungka Café for a lunch of egg noodles with smoked pork, a local specialty.

AFTERNOON Wander through the **Ranong Road Day Market** to shop for southern Thai fabrics and rattan crafts. Then visit the atmospheric **Shrine of the Serene Light**, off Phang-Nga Road, a Chinese temple that is nearly 200 years old.

EVENING Finish the day with a hand-crafted bowl of green curry at Krajok See (see facing page). If you feel like an evening out, head to **Timber Hut** on the Yaowarat Road to enjoy music from local bands.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Phuket **airport** has international flights. There are **planes** and **buses** from Bangkok. A **rental car** is worth considering to get around the island.

WHERE TO STAY

Thalang Guest House (inexpensive) offers simple, clean rooms in a Straits Settlement town house. www.thalangguesthouse.com

Sino House Phuket Hotel and Apartment (moderate) is a boutique hotel mixing vintage and modern decor. www.sinohousephuket.com

Royal Phuket City Hotel (expensive) in the capital of Phuket provides the town’s most luxurious accommodations, with a gym and pool. www.royalphuketcity.com

TOURIST INFORMATION
www.tourismthailand.org